ACT TWO

SCENE 1

Early evening. Three years ago, but we don't know that yet.

The house is messier than we're used to.

JUDY is upstairs, fixing her hair in front of the bedroom mirror. She hears the front door opening and gets up, heads down the stairs.

JOHNNY comes through the front door, in his fifties suit, carrying his work bag. He takes off his hat and hangs it on the hatstand.

JOHNNY: Hello? What are you doing home?

JUDY: I finished early. Hello darling.

JUDY kisses him.

JOHNNY: How are they managing? It's barely six o'clock.

JUDY: Turns out I'm not indispensable.

JOHNNY: I'd have to disagree.

JOHNNY kisses her. JUDY kisses him back for longer than he expects.

Hello.

JUDY: I've made you a cocktail, come through.

JOHNNY: Wow.

They go into the living room. JUDY bustles at the bar, putting ice into a drink she's already mixed.

JUDY: Did you know they're pulling down the old cereal factory?

JOHNNY: What? No.

JUDY: I bumped into Sheila who I used to work with – the one who left to work at the council? – and she said they're

pulling it down. I just bumped into her coming out of the Spar.

JOHNNY: But it's a landmark.

JUDY: They're going to build a new shopping centre which must be the absolutely last thing we need.

She hands him his drink.

JOHNNY: Lovely. What is it?

JUDY: It's an Old Fashioned.

They sit.

JOHNNY: And how was day?

JUDY: Oh gosh you'll love this

JOHNNY: *(re the drink)* This is delicious.

JUDY: Is it? Good.

JUDY tries hers.

Ooh, yes. So Richard

JOHNNY: Richard?

JUDY: One of the partners? Head of Tax.

JOHNNY: Yes.

JUDY: Basically been there forever, way before the merger, probably the merger before that,

JOHNNY: How old?

JUDY: Old. Nearly retiring. Hasn't given a shit in some time.

JOHNNY: Right.

JUDY: And we've all known that – but I found out today

JOHNNY: From

JUDY: I got talking to Becky, his PA, in the coffee corner – she was having a cappuccino which takes forever with that machine, the nozzle gets clogged.

Anyway it turns out the reason Richard takes so long to reply when anyone sends him an email is he doesn't know how to use a computer.

JOHNNY: What?

JUDY: I know, can you imagine? This day and age. I don't care how old you are.

Becky prints out all his emails for him at the end of the day – massive waste of paper – then on the train back to Peterborough he writes his responses freehand on the printouts, and in the morning he hands the stack of paper back to her and she types them up and sends them.

JOHNNY: That's hilarious.

JUDY: Isn't that extraordinary?

JOHNNY: Amazing.

JUDY: I mean god knows what his salary is. Five times mine.

JOHNNY: More than.

JUDY: Anyway.

What a wanker.

They laugh.

Nice, isn't it, me being home when you get back?

JOHNNY: No, lovely.

JUDY: I've got something to talk to you about.

JOHNNY: God, are you pregnant?

JUDY: No?

Pregnant?

JOHNNY: I don't know, women start nesting and stuff, don't they, when they're

JUDY: Because I made you a cocktail I'm pregnant?

JOHNNY: No, sorry, go on.

JUDY: God Johnny, that's really peed on my actual news.

JOHNNY: Sorry. Go on.

JUDY: OK so Chris made an announcement today. They're scaling back the Welwyn office, and they're looking for some people to take voluntary redundancy. Before they start on the less voluntary kind.

JOHNNY: They wouldn't get rid of you.

JUDY: Chris called me in this afternoon and basically invited me to leave before I'm pushed.

JOHNNY: Ah.

I'm sorry love.

JUDY: Thing is, I suddenly thought yeah, fuck it. Take the redundancy package and leave. It's generous, what they're offering.

JOHNNY: Wait, have you left already? Is that why you're home, you just walked out?

JUDY: No no. I just finished early, I just decided to. I had this feeling that I really wanted to be here to greet you. Instead of leaving the office at seven and racing home to find you eating crisps and frowning into the fridge.

JOHNNY: I like crisps, I don't mind.

JUDY: The thing is I'm thinking it'd be nice to be home to greet you every day.

JOHNNY: No, sounds lovely.

JUDY: Well that's what I'm thinking. Take the redundancy package and not get another job. Make being here my job, looking after us, you, the house.

What d'you think?

JOHNNY: You mean you'd be a what, be a housewife?

JUDY: We'd really be in the fifties.

JOHNNY giggles.

What's funny?

JOHNNY: Well you don't really, um. Cook.

JUDY: I'd learn, wouldn't I?

I can manage a team of six people and a portfolio of corporate clients, I can learn to cook things.

JOHNNY: No, sorry.

JUDY: I could do a class, a course maybe.

I didn't think you'd laugh.

JOHNNY: Are you serious?

JUDY: I thought you might like the idea.

JOHNNY: No it's a lovely idea I just

Well it's a bit radical, isn't it? I don't know anyone who – I mean anyone our age, who

JUDY: We'd be rebels.

They laugh together.

JOHNNY: We couldn't afford it, surely.

JUDY: I've had a look at the numbers, I did some back-of-an-envelope this morning and then checked the real figures when I got home and I think

You've got a really good salary and you've been exceeding your commission target, haven't you? No reason to think you can't stay at the top of the leader board, Mike sending you out as his best valuer.

And me being at home might save us money actually. I'd cook things from scratch, that's supposed to be cheaper. All the petrol money I'd save not driving to that stupid business park.

JOHNNY: All the grief you'd save.

JUDY: Yes.

JOHNNY: And not bringing work home.

JUDY: No, we'd get our weekends back. Especially once the house is finished.

JOHNNY: Which we'll do quicker if you're

JUDY: I'll be all yours. Wouldn't it be wonderful?

Think about it: the house is clean, everything's put away. No more tripping over things on the stairs. A fridge full of food, dinner in the oven already before you get back. Clean sheets on the bed, the pillows fluffed up.

JOHNNY: Could grow some things in the garden.

JUDY: Yes, vegetables, I could learn that.

JOHNNY: Dig for Victory!

JUDY: Except that's forties.

JOHNNY: No, I know.

JUDY: And you go out to work as before, nothing different except you feel like a real provider. My rock. My Rock Hudson. My man, out in the world all day. Knowing I'm here at home waiting for you.

JOHNNY: It isn't a bit sexist, maybe?

JUDY: Only if someone's doing something they don't want to do.

This is us making a choice. Together. Sharing out the work in a different way.

JUDY kneels down in front of JOHNNY, starts to take off his shoes.

Then you'd come through the door in the evening,

JOHNNY: 'Darling I'm home!'

JUDY: And I come out to meet you, I've got a drink ready for you. You get through the door and you put all your cares away in the drawer with your work phone. You sit down and I take your shoes off and give you your slippers and your drink, wouldn't that be nice?

JUDY puts his slippers on his feet.

And dinner ready whenever you're hungry, and the whole evening to ourselves, whatever you want to do. You'd never have to remember just before bed to iron a shirt for the morning.

JOHNNY: Oh god I hate ironing my shirts.

JUDY: The wardrobe's full of shirts, all ironed and ready.

And, you know, at night, I wouldn't be so tired. Neither of us would be so tired.

JOHNNY: Or in the morning.

JUDY: Or in the morning. And everywhere so clean. Surfaces you could eat your breakfast off, every surface clean enough to do whatever we like on.

JOHNNY: You haven't been happy at work in so long. If I could save you that

JUDY: I'd get six months' redundancy, we could call it a trial.

JOHNNY: I guess if it. If it was Cornwall, say, if Cornwall was our favourite place, we'd maybe have had a cottage there

for years, for the weekends, but eventually we'd want to go and live there, maybe, wouldn't we?

JUDY: And that's how we feel about the fifties. This would mean we could live there all the time.

I think we might find we love it.

JOHNNY: Yes.

JUDY: Yes?

JOHNNY: Yes. Yes, OK, yes.

JUDY claps with joy. She kisses JOHNNY.

JUDY: I'm so happy.

JOHNNY: Good.

JUDY: How d'you feel?

JOHNNY: I'm just thinking about all those surfaces

JUDY: D'you want to go upstairs?

JOHNNY: Upstairs before dinner? Yes, why not.

JUDY: No reason.

JOHNNY: No reason.

JOHNNY drains his cocktail, stands and kisses her.

JUDY takes his hand and leads him up to the bedroom. Once there, they kiss and sink back onto the bed.

SCENE 2

Two a.m. JUDY is sitting at the kitchen table, in a dressing gown, staring ahead of her.

JOHNNY comes in the front door quietly.

JUDY stands up, goes to the sink and busies herself drying some dishes.

JOHNNY comes into the kitchen and sees JUDY.

JUDY: Where've you been?

JOHNNY: Went for a drive.

JUDY: It's two o'clock.

JOHNNY: They've gone, have they? Fran and Marcus.

JUDY: Of course they've gone, it's two o'clock.

I don't know when I've been so embarrassed.

JOHNNY: Is that what we're going to focus on?

JUDY stops.

JUDY: D'you want some tea?

JOHNNY: No.

JUDY: Are you hungry?

JOHNNY: I thought you'd be asleep.

JUDY: I didn't know where you were.

JOHNNY: My head was bursting.

JUDY: Johnny, I'm sorry about the bank letter. I didn't show you because you panic about

JOHNNY: We're supposed to share things like that. Squirrelling things under the sink that's not a marriage.

JUDY: I thought I could sort it out.

JOHNNY sits down at the table.

JOHNNY: I had an idea. It's not perfect but it might give us some time, OK? Time to get straight.

JUDY: What is it?

JOHNNY: We use some of the money your dad left you.

I know you're supposed to save it for something special, but if it's just temporary while we get back on our feet, he wouldn't mind that, would he?

I know it's sacred that money and we don't touch it but

JUDY: It's gone, Johnny.

JOHNNY: It's gone?

JUDY: I've been using it to plug the gap.

JOHNNY: Your rainy day money?

JUDY: I guess it's been a pretty wet year. The fridge, the car and

JOHNNY: We haven't had that many repairs, have we?

JUDY: Just a little bit each month, but it adds up.

JOHNNY: You've burned through all of it?

JUDY: Yeah.

JOHNNY: Could we ever afford this?

JUDY: Yes, when there was more money coming in.

JOHNNY: When you had a job.

JUDY: After that.

JOHNNY: When?

JUDY: Don't make me

JOHNNY: When?

JUDY: OK, when your salary was bigger.

When we started this. There was. More commission.

JOHNNY: So it's me.

JUDY: It's not your fault, it's the market, isn't it?

JOHNNY: My failure to provide.

JUDY: I didn't say that. The promotion was going to sort it out.

JOHNNY: Sorry, am I being massively lower middle class about this? You don't start spending the money till you've got it.

JUDY: We were sure you'd get it.

JOHNNY: So if I can't bring enough money in to fund this life, we have to stop, don't we?

JUDY: It's just the finance, just give me a chance to sort out the finance. I'm truly truly sorry, I was trying to protect you

JOHNNY: I'm a big boy I don't need

JUDY: This is what I'm saying, I made a mistake and I'm sorry, but leave it with me and I'll try and think of a way round it because it doesn't need to be a thing that knocks us off course, does it? You wouldn't be saying all this about wanting to stop if you hadn't found that letter, would you?

Would you?

JOHNNY: I think maybe Alex coming here lost me the promotion.

JUDY: No.

JOHNNY: Don't you think it's maybe a bit of a turnoff, knowing someone gets waited on at home, wouldn't you kind of lose respect for them a bit?

JUDY: Let me talk to her, I can talk to her if you

JOHNNY: No, god.

JUDY: Why does it matter what anyone else thinks? If we choose to share out the tasks in our marriage in a different way from

JOHNNY: OK, you're not going to listen let's go to bed.

JUDY: I'm listening.

JOHNNY: Let's go to bed, talk about it in the morning.

JUDY: No, Johnny. I've sat here all evening waiting for you, worried about what you'll be coming back in with.

JOHNNY: I'm tired.

JUDY: So am I.

JOHNNY: How can you be tired? You don't do anything.

Sorry.

JUDY: Where did that come from?

JOHNNY: OK, look. Your life and my life, there's.

You don't vacuum the living room one day, I probably wouldn't even notice. You forget to cook, what's the worst thing that happens? We order a pizza, no biggie. Oh my god, my slippers are cold, what'll we do?

It's not having to deal with people, make decisions all day, knowing the impact on your place on the target board, on the face you get to wear when you walk into the office. You don't have any of that.

JUDY: Doesn't mean I can't understand, can't support you.

JOHNNY: You feel a million miles away.

JUDY: I'm here.

JOHNNY: It's like talking to someone underwater.

JUDY: I'm here, Johnny, I'm here.

JOHNNY: I feel like we're performing it. Performing our relationship. I have to get home every night at the same time so we can do this little dance of cocktails and dinner,

JUDY: I make you dinner it's a nice thing.

JOHNNY looks at JUDY.

Sorry, I'm listening.

JOHNNY: Whatever we were trying to do, it

What must we look like?

JUDY: It doesn't matter what anyone else thinks.

JOHNNY: What about what I think? Do we care what I think?

I think we might have got it all wrong.

I'm supposed to feel like a pig in shit, lucky Johnny.

It actually makes me feel like a child, I feel

I feel like the whole thing is just some kind of delusion we're

JUDY: Johnny this is real. This is us, this is how we're supposed to be.

This is us finally living life like we want to. If other people have a problem with it they're probably just jealous of how happy we are. How everything we do is about making each other happy, making the fantasy happen for each other. Not every couple has that, we're bloody lucky. What we have is so good. It's not about the money, the money's not important. We've made a real home.

"Are you happy, darling?" "Yes, disgracefully". We say it as a joke, but it's true, isn't it? Our mornings together, our evenings, our nights.

JOHNNY: I'm not.

JUDY: Not what?

JOHNNY: Happy.

I

I'm sorry, I'm not.

JUDY: Why?

JOHNNY looks away, looks down. Thinks before he speaks.

JOHNNY: Nothing's happened, I promise nothing's happened

JUDY: What?

What, Johnny?

JOHNNY: I've been having feelings for

JUDY: Feelings

JOHNNY: For a person. About a person.

A woman.

Nothing's happened.

But there's been an

Attraction.

JUDY: Who is it?

JOHNNY: It doesn't matter.

JUDY: Of course it matters of course it

JOHNNY: Because thinking about it tonight I think it's more that things aren't right here.

JUDY: Who is it?

Is it Alex?

It's Alex

JOHNNY: It's not about her, it's not about who it is

JUDY: Is it Alex?

JOHNNY: Yes, OK, if it makes a difference to

JUDY: Well it's nice to put a face to it, isn't it?

This woman you

JOHNNY: You're not listening, nothing's happened.

JUDY: Stop saying that, it makes me think something has.

JOHNNY: Nothing's going to happen.

JUDY: Then why tell me?

So I can think about it while I clean the house?

While I iron your shirts, starch your collars, wondering where you are, who you're with?

While I scrub the potatoes? On my hands and knees polishing the floor?

How dare you bring me this? Drop it at my feet like a wet sock off the washing line? After everything I've done, Johnny.

JOHNNY: I never

I'm trying to be honest.

I wanted your help.

JUDY: Selfish.

JOHNNY: I didn't tell you for you to get hurt about it, it was an example of

Something's not right. The way we're living, it

You don't seem to know what it's done to you.

JUDY: I'm happy with it you're the one

You're the one suddenly saying it's broken.

JUDY goes to the cutlery drawer, takes it out and brings it back to the table, then upturns it. The cutlery clatters out onto the table.

JOHNNY: What are you doing?

JUDY: Cutlery needs polishing.

JOHNNY: It's three o'clock in the morning.

JUDY: I'm not sleepy now.

Sunday night, I should have done it earlier only I was too upset.

JOHNNY: Judy

JUDY: Don't.

JUDY takes out a cloth and a tin of polish. She sits down.

JOHNNY watches helplessly.

JUDY starts polishing the cutlery.

Don't tell me next time.

Telling me only hurts me, doesn't it? Just selfish, getting it off your

I think in future if there's ever anything

If you ever find yourself having feelings again

Be man enough to keep it to yourself. However far it goes.

If that's what it takes to keep this, this arrangement as you call it, then fine. Go off and do it.

JOHNNY: I don't want to

JUDY: Listen to me, I've listened to you.

I expect you to make damn sure I never know. Before, during and after. I expect you to do me that honour in return for everything I do for you.

JOHNNY watches JUDY as she lays the pieces of finished cutlery carefully back in their tray.

SCENE 3

JUDY by the sink, assembling cups etc for tea. SYLVIA sits at the table, looking at the fridge.

SYLVIA: When was it, 1955, something like that. I was fascinated by the way it hummed. I'd creep down in the night and listen to it.

But a fridge that doesn't work, that's literally just a cupboard, isn't it? A cupboard with a light in. If the light's even working.

JUDY: It's fine, it's all working fine now.

JUDY opens the fridge, looks inside.

SYLVIA: Is it? OK good.

JUDY shuts the fridge.

JUDY: I haven't got any milk.

SYLVIA: Are you alright?

JUDY: I was going to go out shopping this morning then I didn't.

Shall we have a drink-drink?

SYLVIA looks at her watch.

SYLVIA: Yes, why not?

They go into the living room.

JUDY: I fancy a gin and lemon, what about you?

SYLVIA: Oh, anything. Yes, gin.

JUDY mixes them a drink.

Is everything alright, darling?

JUDY: Yes, why?

SYLVIA: You asked me to come over, and now I'm here you seem a bit

JUDY hands SYLVIA her drink.

Thank you. Strung out.

JUDY: I might have a little cigarette, would you like one?

SYLVIA: A cigarette?

JUDY: I sometimes have a cigarette in the afternoon, just the one

SYLVIA: Go on, then.

JUDY: You need a little vice, don't you?

JUDY takes two cigarettes out of a case and hands one to SYLVIA. She lights it for her.

SYLVIA: Thank you.

JUDY lights her own. She sits back and inhales.

Ooh. D'you know I haven't had a cigarette in ages?

JUDY: Aren't they lovely?

SYLVIA: Very nice.

JUDY: Those new things they have now instead of cigarettes. People standing in doorways sucking on a biro.

SYLVIA: Oh I know. Vape.

JUDY: What?

SYLVIA: That's what it's called, vaping. Supposed to be better for you.

JUDY: I don't think it harms just once in a while, just a little treat.

Wasn't bad for you in the fifties, of course.

SYLVIA: Well it was.

JUDY: No I know but

SYLVIA: It was just as bad – worse, even, because they didn't have the filters

JUDY: No, OK.

SYLVIA: And they didn't have as good healthcare if you got emphysema or whatever.

JUDY: OK, Mum.

SYLVIA: Was there something you wanted to talk about?

JUDY: The thing is, it's

I need to ask you something. I've never asked you before, never.

SYLVIA: Go on.

JUDY: Johnny didn't get that promotion.

SYLVIA: Oh, I'm sorry.

JUDY: It's OK, he's OK, but

Well it's left us with quite a shortfall, we were rather banking on it. Our mortgage hasn't paid this month.

SYLVIA: Oh, darling.

JUDY: So I wanted to ask if. If maybe you could help me with some money.

I'm sorry, I've never asked before. Not since university.

SYLVIA: I haven't really got any.

JUDY: I thought Erica left you some.

SYLVIA: Yes but Probate, darling. I haven't got it yet.

Could you use some of your father's money?

JUDY: I have, I've used it up. It wasn't that much really, after the deposit on the house. I mean it was wonderful of him, it's kept me going for years.

SYLVIA: And now it's my turn?

JUDY: I just thought you might want to help. Especially now you've got more than you expected to have.

SYLVIA: I couldn't use the money Erica left me to fund your lifestyle, what would she say?

JUDY: It's not a *lifestyle*, you make it sound like I'm buying shoes and handbags all day.

This isn't a lifestyle, it's my life.

Dad would understand.

SYLVIA: Oh, Dad would understand, perfect Dad.

JUDY: I never said he was perfect, he got closer than a lot of

He loved you, and you

The doorbell rings.

SYLVIA: Who's that?

JUDY: I don't know.

JUDY goes down the hallway, opens the door. FRAN is there.

Oh hello.

FRAN: Hi how are you?

JUDY: Sorry, I'd forgotten you were coming.

FRAN: No, I wasn't, I just

Sorry, Marcus is at home and I needed to get out of the house so I said I'd made plans to see you – isn't that awful? Then I thought I might as well come and see if you're in so it's not a complete lie.

I can go if you

JUDY: No no, come in. My mum's here.

FRAN: Oh lovely. I told him I wanted to see how you were, after

JUDY: This is my mum.

FRAN: Hello.

SYLVIA: Sylvia.

FRAN: Hello I'm Fran. I'm so glad you're here.

(To JUDY.) We've been worried about you, I've never seen Johnny so

Saying he wanted to stop!

I always hold you and Johnny up as the perfect marriage so it's like, if they're having problems what hope in hell do me and Marcus have, you know?

SYLVIA: Wanted to stop what?

FRAN: When he said he wanted to stop the fifties thing.

SYLVIA: Johnny wants to stop the fifties thing?

FRAN: Oh. Shit, sorry.

JUDY: He was in a state, that's all, he doesn't really want to.

SYLVIA: But that's what he said.

JUDY: We're having gin, Fran – d'you want one?

FRAN: More than anything, yeah.

JUDY pours FRAN a drink.

Is Johnny here?

JUDY: Work.

FRAN: 'Course.

JUDY: Marcus isn't?

FRAN: He's off work for a bit, actually.

He's been having a bit of trouble. His, um

JUDY hands FRAN her drink.

Thank you.

It's appalling, really, it's

He's had a complaint, an allegation of. His PA has

She's alleging inappropriate physical contact. Sexual harassment. They've sent him home while the other partners review the situation.

JUDY: God.

FRAN: This girl, she's

She's worked with him for years, never said anything was

SYLVIA: What's she alleging? Sorry, it's none of my

FRAN: She says he groped her.

JUDY: No.

FRAN: They've taken away his swipe card.

And you know, there's no evidence for this, it's her word against his, so

JUDY: It's probably just a misunderstanding, isn't it?

FRAN: I hope so.

I mean you know Marcus, he's

He's huggy, isn't he? He's

JUDY: Tactile.

FRAN: It's part of what people like, he's just a big teddy bear, isn't he? It's never, you know, it's never creepy.

You'd have to be totally over-sensitive to think he was

God. I don't know what's going to happen.

Anyway, he'll have to stop badgering me about leaving my job if he's about to lose his.

(To JUDY.) I brought your book back.

FRAN takes the book from her bag.

JUDY: Useful?

FRAN: Yeah, very. I'd never live up to it, but yeah.

SYLVIA: What's this one?

FRAN hands the book to SYLVIA.

JUDY: It's just a

Historical

SYLVIA: You're recruiting now?

JUDY: It's household tips Mum, it's not

SYLVIA: It's inflammatory material. I thought it was your choice, didn't need to drag anyone else along?

JUDY: I don't. Fran was asking.

FRAN: What d'you do, Fran?

FRAN: I'm a stylist. Films and commercials. Commercials, mainly.

SYLVIA: Wonderful.

FRAN: I like it. I'm good at it.

SYLVIA: Good. Don't let my daughter lure you away from it.

FRAN: No, well we can't afford it now, not if there's going to be legal costs and

JUDY: You think it could

FRAN: He thinks she's out to destroy him, bring the company down with her.

SYLVIA: Why would she do that?

FRAN: I don't know, but that's what he's scared of.

JUDY: Poor Marcus.

FRAN: He's too trusting, that's his problem.

JUDY: He's old fashioned.

FRAN: He's so upset. I've never seen him so

He didn't want to to tell me, only this girl has a lot of friends on Twitter.

He said he just tries to be friendly with everyone, he puts his arm around the shoulders of his male colleagues all the time.

I believe him, but you can't help, you can't help wondering, can you? Thinking maybe he's different with other people than he is with me, maybe there's a side to him I don't know, or

JUDY: What's happened to us if you can't put your arm around someone's shoulders without them crying assault?

FRAN: And he's hurt that she didn't speak to him about it – they worked together for years, she could have said to him 'sorry Marcus I don't like that' or something. He'd have stopped straight away.

SYLVIA: Well it's not that easy, is it? When it's your boss. Who's got the power in that situation? She might have felt that if she said anything he'd have her removed, she might have been in fear for her job. We don't have any idea what she might have gone through.

JUDY: Mum

SYLVIA: She isn't necessarily out to ruin him, she might just want to do her job without being undermined or manhandled.

JUDY: Mum. This is Fran's husband

SYLVIA: Yes I'm sorry, I don't mean to say

But we don't know her, do we?

JUDY: You don't know Marcus either. She might be lying for all we know.

SYLVIA: Why would she? At great personal risk

JUDY: I don't know, because she's a fantasist, maybe?

SYLVIA: You'd know, I suppose.

JUDY: What?

SYLVIA: Fantasist. You'd know.

JUDY: You mean I'm

SYLVIA: This gingham paradise you've made for yourself – you know it's not real, don't you? The fifties didn't even look like this in the fifties. You're living in a cartoon.

You want to know what the fifties were like, from someone who was actually there? The fifties were terrible. The idea that anyone would want to would choose to go back there, it's ridiculous.

The pair of you in your frocks, look at you.

Do you know how cold it was? November right through to March. Everyone huddled round their own fireplace, cause everywhere else was freezing. The whole house except about a yard around the sitting room fire where it was boiling, the rest of it bone-cold. It bit your nose off in the morning. I'd offer to help mum with the dinner, not to spend time with her, just so I could stand next to the oven.

Sundays that lasted a month, nothing open, nothing to do. Church. Freezing. But you couldn't not go.

Rationing! Still rationing. Bread you could build houses with. Tiny meals, never feeling properly full except at Christmas. And god it was bland: grey meat, grey people, everything grey. My dad came home once with this

amazing new food a friend had been talking about – Mum wouldn't let us eat it cause she'd heard it was made out of mould. It was yoghurt.

That's being a woman in the fifties. Fear. Walking through a world the war was supposed to have sorted out for you, but it all just looks broken. Bomb-shaped holes everywhere, men like my dad back from the war with their body intact but their head different. Everyone making do and mending, things that were already wrecked. And the intolerance: try being anything other than a straight white man and see if you still think it's utopia.

And don't expect not to be groped at work, that's the least of your worries. Your husband is legally allowed to fuck you whenever he wants to, it doesn't matter how bad things are between you, or how many too-many children you've got or how much your head aches or your back aches or you can't stand the sight of him anymore, the weight of him on you. And no abortion, no birth control. No help anywhere. Divorce him? Good luck, love. Whatever he got up to, you turned a blind eye to it.

My poor mother. Frightened of a yoghurt.

She said to me as she was dying – in the hospice – she said 'what have I done, really?' I said don't say that, you brought up three children, that's not nothing, what's more important than that? But I didn't believe it, she didn't believe it, she knew. Her life was wasted. All her potential boiled down to such a bitter little existence.

She probably turned a blind eye to all sorts of rubbish and look where it got her. You know what she'd do if she saw you now? She'd laugh.

JUDY: Anything else?

SYLVIA: Yes. Your father.

JUDY: Mum

SYLVIA: Why do you think I left him?

JUDY: I thought we were doing the fifties.

SYLVIA: We are. Somewhere along the way you've taken your father with his abundant faults, mixed him up with James Stewart and Gregory Peck and made a perfect 1950's gentleman and I'm sorry but he wasn't he really wasn't.

Charming, yes, charismatic yes certainly. He was a very charming, charismatic man when he wanted to be, but I was the only one who really understood him. Except I wasn't the only woman who thought that.

JUDY: He's not here to defend himself, this isn't

SYLVIA: I could name you four or five others. Over the years. That I knew about.

It's a desperate feeling. I wouldn't wish it on anyone. I felt embarrassed to exist.

I'm sorry darling, if that's a shock. But there it is.

(To FRAN.) I went on for years, not listening when I had doubts. It's no good. Listen to your gut, trust your gut. If your gut says he's done something, he probably has.

SCENE 4

Late morning. JUDY is in the kitchen.

ALEX is upstairs in the bedroom, looking into the wardrobe at JUDY's dresses. She closes the wardrobe quietly, picks up a notebook and comes downstairs.

JUDY: Got everything you need?

ALEX: Yes, for now. Once we've signed the agreement we'll come back and measure up for a floor plan, get photos etcetera.

JUDY: Right, um

ALEX: Shall we sit down and I'll talk you through

JUDY: I mean I don't know if we're ready to

ALEX: Just want to take you through our pack so you know what you're getting if you list the house with us.

ALEX stands by the table, takes out some papers and brochures from her bag and lays them out.

JUDY: Right.

JUDY comes to sit down opposite.

ALEX: It's a sole agency agreement, minimum of twenty weeks on the market but it won't take that long, things are really getting snapped up right now.

This is one of our standard brochures, you can see it's all nicely presented, but if you like you can pay upfront for Enhanced Marketing, so you get a glossier brochure like this plus your listing comes up first when anyone searches on the website or one of the big meta sites, your Prime Location or Right Move, whatever.

But I wouldn't push that on you because I really think our standard service is what they'd call premium in other agencies. We're all about working closely with clients, making sure you feel valued and listened to, and obviously helping you quickly find a good quality buyer without any of the bullshit you get sometimes, you know?

JUDY: You're good at this.

ALEX: Thanks.

Am I? I don't do many valuations now I'm managing a branch, so

I thought you said you weren't ever moving.

JUDY: I'm just thinking about it at the moment, just considering

ALEX: It's a good time, very much a vendor's market.

JUDY: And how much would we

ALEX: Obviously I need to go back and do a proper evaluation based on all the info I've

JUDY: I was hoping we could just informally, just an idea really.

ALEX: Off the top of my head?

JUDY: Sorry. I didn't realise you'd have to go through the whole

ALEX: It's like Antiques Roadshow, people are just waiting to hear a number.

These are going for four, four-fifty at the moment.

JUDY: OK.

ALEX: But that's very much a ballpark. Where are you going?

JUDY: Going?

ALEX: Moving to.

JUDY: Nowhere just

ALEX: Nowhere

JUDY: Somewhere smaller, maybe. Cheaper.

I'm sure you know, but

Mike had, before he left, he had very much led Johnny to believe he'd be the next Assistant Manager.

ALEX: Yes, Mike shouldn't have done that. Especially when he knew he was going to retire.

JUDY picks up one of the leaflets.

JUDY: You couldn't consider, um, reconsidering, could you?

ALEX: Reconsider the appointment?

JUDY: Toby's wife's a doctor, isn't she? They've got plenty of

Sorry, I shouldn't ask only I know Johnny won't. I know you and Johnny, um. I know you get on very well.

ALEX: It wasn't just my decision. I can put people forward, but the decision's taken at regional board level.

JUDY: Did you put Johnny forward?

ALEX: No, not this

JUDY: You didn't even put him forward?

ALEX: It's better for him that I didn't because he's not ready, and I wouldn't want them to remember him next time round as someone who's not

Johnny's target at the moment is to list four houses a week, but all this year it's been more like two and half, the occasional three.

So if I'm putting someone forward to regional management, they're going to be looking at those numbers and asking me why I think this person's ready for a bigger role, and being verbally promised a job by someone who's subsequently left the company isn't going to cut it.

JUDY: I wish they cared about length of service or loyalty or

ALEX: They're running a business.

I've talked him through all of this, I'm sorry if he hasn't explained it all to you. Do you see his payslips?

JUDY: Of course.

ALEX: So you'll know he's been getting less commission, considerably less than

JUDY: Yes.

ALEX: For some time.

JUDY: Yes.

ALEX: So what do you think it is?

JUDY: I know the market's been tough.

ALEX: Well we adjust the targets to take that into account.

He asked me, in his one to one the other day. He wondered if it was his clothes. Or turning up in a fifties car.

JUDY: He asked you that?

ALEX: It's obviously on his mind, he knows he's not doing as well.

JUDY: He's always felt dressing a bit differently made him distinctive, made him memorable. It's his thing.

What did you say? In this one to one?

ALEX: I said I'm sure it's not the clothes per se. But if the clothes are making him feel

It's the psychology, it's all about confidence. People can smell it, can't they? You need to project confidence so people want to work with you cause you seem like you're winning. Maybe Johnny doesn't feel like he's winning for some reason.

A lot of our business gets picked up by word of mouth, so of course if you're on a good streak, people tell their friends and you get more business off that. If you're on a less-good streak, then

JUDY: So how does he turn it around?

ALEX: I said to him you've got to look at everything, everything in your life, work out what it is that's putting you off balance. And then do something about it.

JUDY: Do something about it like what?

ALEX: I don't know. Not for me to say.

Do you want me to value the house? Or is this just

Because it's quite a lot of paperwork and if you're not really intending to

JUDY: No, let's leave it.

ALEX: Right.

ALEX gathers up her things. She stops and looks at JUDY.

I'll bear it in mind, OK? What you've said. I can't see anything coming up, someone would have to leave and I can't see that happening soon, but

JUDY: Please don't take him.

ALEX: What?

JUDY: I know you could, we both know you could but please don't.

ALEX: Sorry I don't know what you're talking about.

JUDY: These feelings he's been having – I don't know what's happened between you, I don't know how far it's gone, I don't really want to know I don't think

I mean when I think about it it's you've got keys to empty houses and you can go to one of them together in the afternoon and nobody at the office knows about it not that I can imagine him being so – but you never really know someone, do you, or how they are with other people?

But please. He's all I've got. I might be able to bear it just being a sex thing, but if it's more than that

ALEX: A sex thing sorry what?

A sex thing?

JUDY: Oh my god you didn't

ALEX: Johnny?

JUDY: Oh my god.

ALEX: That would be completely

I'm his boss.

JUDY: I thought he'd told you, I thought it was a mutual

ALEX: Johnny?

JUDY: I'm his wife it's obviously not that hard for me to understand someone being attracted to him.

ALEX: No sorry of course he's lovely but

God no.

OK that makes more sense now.

JUDY: What does?

ALEX: The way he's been behaving.

Right, OK.

Huh.

JUDY: Oh god.

ALEX: God, men are so

JUDY: Please don't tell him I told you?

SCENE 5

Afternoon. JUDY and MARCUS in the living room, with drinks.

MARCUS: And that's why it's called a Screwdriver.

JUDY: Because they stirred it

MARCUS: Yes, with a

JUDY: That's brilliant, I never knew that.

MARCUS: No well no one does really.

JUDY: Is it true, do you think?

MARCUS: I don't know. Why let truth get in the way of a good story?

JUDY: This from the man who looks everything up on the internet.

MARCUS: Ha! No, well you've got me there, haven't you?

MARCUS sits back.

This is nice.

JUDY: We get on, don't we?

MARCUS: Yes, we get on very well.

JUDY: We're good friends.

MARCUS: I'd say so.

JUDY: I've always felt that. Even if it's me and Fran, really, that see each other most often, and you and I don't really see each other without the others but I do always feel

MARCUS: A connection. Which is nice.

JUDY: I think there's a lot of things we agree on. I feel very

About you, I feel

MARCUS: Yes, I do too.

JUDY: Yes?

MARCUS: Yes.

JUDY: I don't see why we shouldn't take that to another level.

MARCUS: Another – sorry?

JUDY: I wondered if I might come and work for you.

MARCUS: Work for me?

JUDY: Fran told me you lost your secretary. PA.

MARCUS: Fran told you the reason, did she? The circumstances behind

JUDY: It's rotten, I'm very sorry.

MARCUS: You know they've sent me home, while they

JUDY: But you'll be back, presumably, soon? Won't you?

MARCUS: I'm off indefinitely. While the other partners *review the situation.*

JUDY: I suppose there's a procedure they have to

MARCUS: Oh yes there's a procedure. Procedure that I put in place, when we set up the agency. Collecting statements from the rest of the staff, anyone I'd been in contact with, anyone that had seen us working together.

JUDY: God.

MARCUS: And you know that's my company. Everything I've worked for.

Hashtags flying around, people who've never met me.

JUDY: It'll blow over, won't it? When they work out she was just looking for attention, or money or whatever?

Presumably she's not coming back?

MARCUS: No.

JUDY: When Fran told me about it, it was like a lightbulb, I just had this idea of *me* as your secretary. Typing your letters, pouring your coffee, your four o'clock whisky. Knowing where you've left your pen or your glasses. Fending people off on the phone when you're up against it. First line of defence, a tiger when you need one, pussycat the rest of the time. Shirts from the cleaners, a spare one in the drawer in case you want to freshen up. Absolute discretion and no questions asked.

MARCUS: But why would you want to be

I thought you were very happy here?

JUDY: Well, circumstances. It looks like I'll need to take on some kind of paid something. If we're to stay afloat.

MARCUS: This job that Johnny didn't get.

JUDY: And I don't know, maybe it's time to shake things up a bit, I've had three lovely years of

MARCUS: But a secretary: aren't you over-qualified? You used to manage a team, didn't you?

JUDY: I'm not looking for something at that level now.

I want something simpler. Clearer.

I like the idea of helping someone.

Maybe it's a romantic idea, I just quite like the thought of working on one of those old typewriters, cardigan round my shoulders, you know?

MARCUS: Pencil skirt and heels.

JUDY: Of course.

MARCUS: Take a letter Miss Martin! Glasses?

JUDY: Only when I think you're out of the office.

MARCUS laughs.

I mean I know no one really, those old typewriters

MARCUS: Don't send email, sadly.

JUDY: No. I'm not sure that's better.

MARCUS: Tell me something. If I came into the office in the morning and said 'that's a nice cardigan', would you be alright with that?

JUDY: Why wouldn't I?

MARCUS: I find it quite hard, if I see a nice cardi, say, not to say anything.

JUDY: No well that's normal, I think.

MARCUS: Or if you looked particularly nice that day, if you'd had a good sleep and looked fresh and lovely, would you

mind if I said something? Like 'don't you look fresh and lovely today?'

JUDY: Yes that would be fine.

MARCUS: You wouldn't be offended?

JUDY: No, I'd be glad, compliments are nice.

MARCUS: Where do you stand on contact?

JUDY: With?

MARCUS: Physical contact, I mean. Accidental, like if my hand brushed yours when we both reached for the stapler.

JUDY: Oh but that's – honestly, is that what

MARCUS: You'd be surprised.

JUDY: For heaven's sake.

MARCUS: And say you'd done something for me, something really excellent and I wanted to thank you and I put my hand on your shoulder, the back of your shoulder as I said it.

Like this.

JUDY: Yes of course

MARCUS: Or I was leaning over to congratulate you so I put my arm round your shoulders like this

JUDY: Yes that's fine.

MARCUS: Further down your back? Say here?

JUDY: Yes.

MARCUS: Here?

JUDY: Yes.

But this is me, you know I wouldn't misinterpret

MARCUS: Just being friendly.

JUDY: Yes.

MARCUS moves away.

MARCUS: I mean these women. The power they wield. And they know it, they know they can end you. Watching you all the time, just waiting for you to slip up, say something they can label sexist or racist, something they can enjoy being outraged about. Anything. You can't do anything now. Years where she doesn't object to a compliment, a hand on the arm, nor does she leave me out when she's looking for career advice, looking to *progress,* and doesn't mind doing it over a glass of wine that she's not paying for, the flinty little bitch. Then suddenly boosh it's everything exploded and it's not just now it's historical it's did you *ever,* has it *ever* happened, right back to the first boss who ever patted his PA on the bottom and said 'run along now' as a *joke.*

JUDY: Is that what you did? Patted her on the bottom.

MARCUS: As a joke. I wasn't exactly chasing her round the desk. I don't even find her attractive. She's completely flat-chested, she's no hips to speak of.

JUDY: I'm not sure that's going to help your case, saying that.

MARCUS: No, well. Among friends.

I mean come on, a hand on your arse through several layers of clothing? Grow up. It's not like I fingered her, she'd already made it very clear she wasn't going to let me

JUDY: When did

MARCUS: Oh, years ago.

So anyway. I'm not going back to work anytime soon.

Still want to be my secretary? Still appeal?

JUDY nods.

I'm sure there are things we can do. Now that I've got my afternoons free. If you wanted to put on a pencil skirt and a pair of heels I'd happily provide you with an old typewriter and an enthusiastic audience. On a day when no one could come home early or call round unexpectedly.

JUDY: And you'd pay me for that, would you?

MARCUS: If that's what it takes.

JUDY thinks about it.

She holds out her hand to him. He puts down his drink and kneels in front of her. He runs his hand slowly up her leg from her ankle.

When he gets above her knee she grabs his wrist.

JUDY: No, sorry.

MARCUS sits back on the sofa.

Sorry.

SCENE 6

Evening. JUDY and JOHNNY are at the table, with two takeaway pizza boxes between them, and used plates / cutlery. JOHNNY's finished his pizza, JUDY has eaten half of hers.

JOHNNY is in a work shirt and suit trousers.

JUDY is wearing a pair of modern jeans and a jersey top.

JOHNNY: D'you want any more?

JUDY: No, it's

JOHNNY: Didn't you like it?

JUDY: No, it's very nice, I just

I can't remember what pizza I like.

I might not get chicken on it next time.

JOHNNY: I thought the pineapple was the real bum note.

JUDY: It's *ham* and pineapple you have on pizza, isn't it?

JOHNNY: Hawaiian.

JUDY: There's something chicken and pineapple in one of the recipe books I must have been thinking of that.

Was yours nice?

JOHNNY: Yeah. The spicy sausage was good.

JUDY stands and picks up the plates.

JUDY: Not much washing up, anyway.

JUDY goes to the sink.

JOHNNY: I'll do that. Sit down?

JUDY comes back to the table.

Are those new?

JUDY: What?

JOHNNY: Jeans.

JUDY: Old. Back of the wardrobe.

JOHNNY: Still fit.

JUDY: Housework keeps you trim.

JOHNNY: No, you look good.

JUDY: Good. I feel a bit drab.

JOHNNY: You don't look

JUDY: If it's what you need me to do, I'll work on it.

JUDY sits down.

JOHNNY: I never said I needed you to

JUDY: You said you didn't want us to live in the fifties anymore.

JOHNNY: I wasn't really talking about the clothes we wear.

JUDY: No, of course but it's part, isn't it? I'm doing what I can, Johnny.

JOHNNY clears the pizza boxes.

JOHNNY: I saw um

I saw Alex today, she called me into her office.

She's um. Well it turns out she's been thinking about me.

JUDY: Thinking

JOHNNY: My place in the branch, my role.

JUDY: Right. Right.

JOHNNY: And I think questioning if she did the right thing, promoting Toby

Wanting to put something right, anyway. She's talked to regional management about me and they've offered me a new job, an assistant manager job.

JUDY: Oh.

JOHNNY: But not here. In the St Albans branch.

Which, obviously, isn't that far away, it's just a longer drive.

JUDY: Sure.

JOHNNY: And working with different people, obviously.

JUDY: Is it a bigger

JOHNNY: Bigger office, yeah.

JUDY: Are you going to do it?

JOHNNY: Yes of course.

JUDY: What about your, um. Leaving your colleagues.

JOHNNY: I don't think I've got much choice.

JUDY: But do you want to?

JOHNNY: I think this is the right thing.

JUDY: What's the um

JOHNNY: Salary? Another six K. Plus commission based on the whole branch's targets, because obviously I won't be going out on valuations so much.

JUDY puts a hand to her mouth.

I presume that puts us

JUDY: Out of the woods, yes.

JOHNNY: So there we are.

JUDY: Oh my god.

Oh god.

Oh god Johnny. I can't tell you how

I've been so worried.

JOHNNY: I know.

JUDY: This is good. This'll be good for us.

For you. That they're recognising your potential, I mean.

We'll be fine now. I promise I'll stay on top of it this time, I'll make sure we stay within our means. We can get back to normal, can't we?

JOHNNY: Can we?

JUDY: What d'you mean?

JOHNNY: I don't think it's that simple.

JUDY: How

JOHNNY: The fight we had the other night, I think we uncovered something really big.

I was angry with you for hiding the letter from the bank

JUDY: Which I've apologised for.

JOHNNY: But then you were angry with me for telling you I was having feelings about someone, yes?

JUDY: I think understandably.

JOHNNY: Yes no, listen. I know, just.

I was angry with you for being secretive, you were angry because I'd been open. I want honesty – I need honesty to feel like we're really together. You want to be lied to.

JUDY: I don't for a second want to be lied to.

JOHNNY: You told me I could have an affair but just make sure you never found out.

JUDY: I didn't say I wanted it to happen, I didn't say I'd be glad.

JOHNNY: But don't you see it's a difference? You'll do anything to preserve this fantasy. And I don't want fantasy anymore.

And I think this is a this is kind of a fundamental problem and I don't know how we solve it. It's a whole lot deeper than wearing fifties clothes or not.

JUDY: God, Johnny.

JOHNNY: I mean are we still in tune with each other? Are we looking in the same direction, or do we actually want different things?

JUDY: You're asking if we should or shouldn't even be together, do you realise that?

JOHNNY: Maybe, yeah.

JUDY: This is the second time in a week you've done this to me.

JOHNNY: What?

JUDY: We start a conversation talking about one thing then you suddenly pull out something else that's massive and scary and there's no warning, you just whip it out and I've got to react straight away it's not fair, Johnny. You keep pulling the rug out from under me, I don't know what I'm standing on.

I can't react quickly enough, I feel battered, I feel ambushed.

JOHNNY: You never had a problem keeping up with me in a fight before, you used to wipe the floor with me.

Where's that girl gone?

JUDY: I'm still here, Johnny.

JOHNNY: Large parts of you seem to have got lost in the house somewhere. Your mind, your wit. The bit of you that could finish a conversation even when there's a dirty plate in the sink.

The house looks perfect, you look perfect, but it's like the woman I love has been excavated from inside you. I don't want you agreeing with everything I say, I want you firing back in my face, because that's sexy and that's real and we've lost it.

JUDY: You want things more real?

JOHNNY: Real is good.

JUDY: I don't know, Johnny. I've had more real life than I want recently.

You've no idea what I've been doing, trying to shore things up trying to keep us safe, trying to protect you, treading on eggshells for you.

All so you don't have to hear me say 'look Johnny, you're not earning enough', 'why aren't you selling more houses, why aren't you better at selling houses, why've you got worse at your job?'

I've been putting dresses on eBay, is that real enough for you? I asked my mother for a loan, my bloody mother. All of this so you could feel like a man.

JOHNNY: What, a proper fifties man who has affairs and doesn't tell you?

JUDY: Throw that back in my face.

JOHNNY: Well OK thank you for everything you've been doing but I'm sorry to tell you it hasn't worked.

Why should you have to do this elaborate dance around my embattled masculinity? If that's what living in the fifties means then that's rubbish, isn't it? That's rubbish for both of us. It makes us both smaller.

I don't know how sustainable that is.

JUDY: You still think we should stop.

JOHNNY: Which is more important: the fifties, or you and me?

Because let me go out on a limb here and say I'd pick us out of those two.

JUDY: I don't know who I am without the fifties.

I know it's stupid but I wanted this my whole life. I dreamed of a kitchen like this, a husband coming home wearing a hat. Finding you, and finding out you wanted all that, too, it was

I was so happy.

JOHNNY: Are you happy now?

JUDY: Not

Not with things being like this, no of course not.

JOHNNY: I miss you.

JUDY puts her hand on the table, reaches towards him.

He puts his hand in hers. They stay like that for a while.

JUDY: So what do we do?

JOHNNY: We still love each other, don't we?

JUDY: I do. Do you?

JOHNNY: Yes. So that's good, that's a big tick.

This fifties thing.

We said we'd try it for six months originally, we only said six months. We've done it for three years without questioning, I just think it's time for a review, why don't we look at everything, think about everything?

JUDY: Like what

JOHNNY: Everything. Like, who works who doesn't

JUDY: I work

JOHNNY: Who goes out to work, who works in the kitchen. I might want to cook sometimes, you know?

Maybe you. Maybe you want to be somewhere with people, not here by yourself all the time

JUDY: You mean a job

JOHNNY: Maybe a job. Not your old job – something that made you happier.

JUDY: I don't know, Johnny. Staying at home makes me happy.

JOHNNY: OK. Maybe let's park that idea for now.

This is just us thinking, looking at things. Do we like this, can we change that, how did we end up doing x, y, z?

We've made all these rules, that

Or not even rules, just routines we've got into that cut us off from things we might like. I used to bring you a cup of tea in bed, do you remember?

JUDY: Yes.

JOHNNY: I used to love that. I loved doing that for you, it felt good. It's a nice feeling, doing things for each other.

JUDY: Have I been hogging it, that feeling?

JOHNNY: You do so much. You're amazing. You could do less and still be amazing.

Whose standards are we holding ourselves to? You know, there's no vintage police force coming to check if we're being 100% accurate. We could fuck up sometimes and maybe that'd be fun. We could try things and maybe they don't work but we try something else and we keep trying and the question isn't "is this properly fifties?" but "is this properly us?"

We muddle a bit more, we share things a bit more, sometimes one of us does more or less sometimes we both do absolutely nothing and we spend the day in bed together, have someone bring us curry on a bike. If you fancy wearing a t-shirt one day it isn't a betrayal of everything we stand for.

I'm making this up as I go along here, is it

JUDY: You look five years younger.

JOHNNY: I feel. I feel like this might be it. The answer.

Maybe not the answer. The right question. Bring us back to life.

JUDY: Real life.

JOHNNY: Yes.

We don't have to bin the fifties altogether but let's look at what works for us and what doesn't and mix it up a bit.

That's all I'm asking for. Have we got that in us?

JUDY: Of course. Of course.

JUDY takes a deep breath.

OK. Yes, OK.

JOHNNY: Agreed? We look at everything – everything we do? We work it out together – no assumptions about what the other one wants, no eggshells, no egos. You and me and our beautiful house and we do it differently this time, yes?

JUDY: Yes.

JUDY goes towards the fridge.

Do you want some pudding? I think there's crumble left.

JOHNNY stands up.

JOHNNY: Dance with me?

JUDY: You hate dancing.

JOHNNY: I'm reviewing that. Come on, dance with me.

JUDY comes over to him, and they start to jive together. Really quite badly.

JUDY: Weird, not wearing a dress for this.

After a few moves:

JOHNNY: You're leading again.

JUDY: I'm trying not to. Go on, you lead.

JOHNNY: No, you

JUDY: No, you

JOHNNY: You

JUDY: You

JOHNNY: You.

They laugh. They keep dancing. Music takes over and continues into a....

CODA

Morning. JOHNNY is in the kitchen, in his work suit. He puts the teapot on the table, which is set for breakfast.

As much of this as possible is a dance.

He takes a loaf of sliced bread and methodically puts some in the toaster, and lays some out for making a sandwich.

He makes a sandwich, wraps it and puts it in a lunch box.

JUDY comes out of the bathroom in 1950s-style office wear.

She comes downstairs. JOHNNY comes over. They kiss each other, long and slow.

The toast pops up.

They sit down and JOHNNY pours the tea. JUDY surveys the table.

She gets up, goes to the cupboard and gets out the marmalade.

They eat the toast and drink their tea.

They take the plates to the sink. JUDY starts to run the tap, but JOHNNY points at his watch.

She hesitates, then walks away from the dishes in the sink.

They go into the hallway and each put on a hat.

JUDY hands JOHNNY his briefcase.

JOHNNY hands JUDY her briefcase.

They leave via the front door.

The house is empty.

THE END